Chapter 6

Information Grounds: Theoretical Basis and Empirical Findings on Information Flow in Social Settings[1]

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1. INTRODUCTION

Do you go to a place for a particular reason but wind up sharing information just because other people are there and you start talking? If so, then you are likely participating in an information ground. In this chapter, we discuss how the social atmosphere of such venues as health clinics, beauty and tattoo parlors, bike shops, and sport events can foster information sharing in spontaneous, serendipitous, and planned ways. Moreover, we explain how information ground is a novel and timely framework for studying information behavior in rich and holistic ways, along with results up-to-date from current research.

At face value, the notion of information grounds may appear intuitive and obvious; however, its formal identification as a theoretical notion in the late 1990s fit with other developments in the field of information behavior. Historically, research on information behavior primarily focused on individuals' use of information sources and their socio-demographic characteristics—examinations which Zweizig and Dervin (1977) explained as "use and user studies". These studies, which addressed such questions as "how often is the X system used and by whom?" explained little about the reasons that people engage in information seeking and to what, if any, effect. Research in the early 1980s signaled a breakthrough. Marking the user-centered paradigm (Dervin & Nilan, 1986), several frameworks emerged, such as Dervin's Sense-Making (1992) and Belkin's Anomalous States of Knowledge (Belkin, 2005; Belkin, Oddy, & Brooks, 1982), that focused primarily on the how and why of uses that people make of information systems and cast users in the forefront with emphasis on understanding contextual aspects of the user's situation (Dervin, 1992).

In the 1990s, this research direction was cemented with the biannual, European "Information Seeking in Context" (ISIC) conference series, which pushed researchers to fully consider the holistic impact of context on information behavior. Indeed, two of the most cogent articulations on the nature of context were presented at ISIC by Dervin (1997) and later Kuhlthau (1999). It was this move, together with the proliferation of ethnographic or qualitative methodologies (with its own inherent focus on holistic examination), the

[1]This chapter expands greatly on an overview of information grounds by Fisher (2005).

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advent of using a social constructionist approach (Tuominen & Savolainen, 1997), and a renewed focus on information behavior and everyday life[2] that led to the identification of information grounds.

Before launching our discussion of information grounds research, we wish to acknowledge that the notion of "place" as a research phenomenon is hardly new to scholars in such fields as sociology, anthropology, and geography—especially human geography. For his history dissertation, for example, Relph (1976) explored the nature of place from varied perspectives and highlighted the 1960s work of geographer Fred Lukermann, who characterized "place" as where:

1. Location is fundamental.
2. Nature and culture are involved.
3. Spaces are unique but interconnected and part of a framework of circulation.
4. Spaces are localized.
5. Spaces are emerging or becoming, and have a historical component.
6. Have meaning.

More recently, the monograph *Senses of Place* edited by Feld and Basso (1996) contains ethnographies of what "place" means to such different populations as the Apache of Arizona and the Kaluli people of New Guinea in terms of expressing and knowing. Lippard (1997) in *Lure of the Local: Senses of Place in a Multicentered Society* similarly discusses "place" by blending history, geography, cultural/social studies, and contemporary art. One of the most recent treatises on "place" was published in 2004 by Creswell, a professor of social and cultural geography at the University of Wales. Penned *Place: A Short Introduction*, Creswell colorfully discusses the many dimensions of "place" and explains the difficulties with trying to establish any one universal definition as he explores numerous examples using varied contexts.

The most significant work on place, however, is likely the widely popularized book by Oldenburg (1999, originally published in 1989) entitled *The Great Good Place: Cafes, Coffee Shops, Bookstores, Bars, Hair Salons, and Other Hangouts at the Heart of a Community* that launched the term "The third place" and the respective names of many community-oriented businesses, including "Third Place Books" in downtown Seattle. As its title suggests, Oldenburg asserts that some public places such as coffee shops and hair salons operate as our "third place", meaning it is where one can be found when one is not at home or at work. A veritable social good (and necessity), Oldenburg provides numerous examples of these third places (which he continues as a series of case studies in his edited 2002 book) and conceptualizes on their nature. To be successful and attract people, he argues, as a neighborhood locale a third place must exhibit eight characteristics:

[2]Historically, most studies of information behavior have focused on such elite populations as scientists and engineers, especially as it was these populations for whom the majority of information systems were designed. In the 1960s and 1970s, several landmark studies were conducted on how people seek everyday information. Their approaches, however, involved large-scale surveys that were problematic for several reasons, including expense (Fisher et al., 2005). After a long hiatus during the late 1970 and 1980s, researchers again began focusing on everyday folks but also began drawing upon qualitative methods.